

SPARSH CAMPAIGN: AN INITIATIVE BY NAVEEN JAIN (IAS)

SIX YEARS OF RESILIENT VOLUNTEERISM AGAINST CHILD ABUSE

Darkness cannot drive out darkness, only light can. The Sparsh Campaign stands as a beacon of light, proactively educating children about critical issues like bad touch, different types of harassment, and child sexual abuse.

Inspired by disturbing news of child abuse and the silence around it, Naveen Jain, IAS (2001 batch-Rajasthan), initiated this campaign in August 2019. His goal was to empower children in schools with knowledge about unsafe touch and the risks involved, using simple language and audiovisual aids.

Starting with a few schools in Jaipur, the campaign targeted students from classes 1 to 8 (ages 4-12), conducting sessions to raise awareness about safeguarding themselves. Volunteers committed their Saturdays to this social cause, reaching schools, organizing talks, and overcoming logistical challenges to spread the message of safety. Over six years, with Naveen Jain as the driving force and thousands of volunteers from diverse fields, Sparsh has benefitted over 1.9 million students, teachers, and parents through more than 8,800 sessions. The campaign started with a mission to reach one lakh children within a year and expanded rapidly to cover multiple districts in Rajasthan and neighboring states. The initiative emphasizes the difference between "good touch and bad touch," aiming to protect childhood innocence from pedophiles who exploit children's innocence and ignorance. As demand grew, a district-wise network of NGOs, teachers, and social workers formed, helping the campaign expand its reach and effectiveness.

Creative methods like ice-breaking activities, role plays, and storytelling are used to engage children actively. Attendance certificates are collected from schools and tracked via Google forms to monitor impact. By early 2020, Sparsh had sensitized over six lakh children in more than 2,000 schools.

Alarmingly, crimes against children in India have risen almost tenfold since 2005, reaching an all-time high of 177,335 cases in 2023, a 9.16% increase from 2022 — a crime every three minutes on average. Many abuse cases go unreported to protect senior family members, and boys also face significant risk, often by known persons or relatives. Initially, there was hesitation about including boys in awareness sessions. Sparsh broke this barrier by including boys aged 4-12, building safety circles around all children. To further the cause, an animated film, "Sandesh," featuring a boy as a victim of abuse, was created. This film simplifies complex lessons and highlights that boys can also be victims, helping spread the message effectively. The advent of COVID-19 and school closures posed new challenges. Research during the pandemic showed increased risks of child abuse during lockdowns. Sparsh adapted by moving sessions online, breaking geographical barriers, and including older students and parents. This flexibility expanded Sparsh's influence beyond Rajasthan to several other states.Acknowledging the need for updated content, the team regularly revises the curriculum based on real cases and feedback. A special module was created for teenagers (grades 9-12) to address their specific needs. Two additional modules were introduced in 2022: one for in-service teachers and another for B.Ed students, preparing future educators to guide children on safety. In May 2023, Naveen Jain's appointment as Secretary of Rajasthan's School Education Department marked a turning point. The campaign gained government support to launch the "Surakshit School Surakshit Rajasthan (SSSR)" initiative, reaching over 65,000 government schools. On 26 August 2023, more than 6.3 million students, teachers, and parents were educated on child safety. This milestone earned certification from the World Book of Records, London. What makes Sparsh unique is its paperless, staff-less, hierarchy-free nature, thriving solely on volunteer dedication. The "Saturday for Society" ethos inspires volunteers to use their free time for this cause without any financial burden. The campaign has spread beyond Rajasthan to states like Jammu and Kashmir, Gujarat, Manipur, Haryana, Madhya Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh, Maharashtra, Delhi, and Uttarakhand. The ongoing mission envisions a safer future for children with the rallying cry: "Save Childhood: Save Innocence," staying inspired to do more each day. As Robert Frost wrote, "We have miles to go before we sleep."



